

DGads CMS Setup & Environment Guide

Step-by-Step Instructions for MongoDB Atlas, Cloudinary & Vercel Deployment

Overview: This guide outlines how to generate all required environment (.env) variables for **MongoDB Atlas** (Free Database) and **Cloudinary** (Free Media CDN), and how to connect them to your live **Vercel** Deployment.

Part 1: MongoDB Atlas Setup (Free Database)

MongoDB Atlas stores all structured JSON text content (case study details, testimonials, client logos metadata, and contact form lead submissions).

- **Step 1: Sign Up** — Go to mongodb.com/cloud/atlas/register and create a free account.
- **Step 2: Create Free Cluster** — Choose the **M0 (FREE)** cluster tier.
- **Step 3: Create Database User** — Click **Connect** ➔ **Create a Database User**. Enter a username (e.g., `dgads_user`) and password. *Save this password securely!*
- **Step 4: Configure Network Access** — Go to **Network Access** ➔ Click **Add IP Address** ➔ Select **Allow Access From Anywhere (0.0.0.0/0)**. This allows Vercel serverless API functions to connect to MongoDB.
- **Step 5: Copy Connection String** — Click **Connect** ➔ **Choose Drivers (Node.js)**. Copy the URI string.

Example Connection String (MONGODB_URI):

```
mongodb+srv://dgads_user:YourStrongPassword123!@cluster0.abcde.mongodb.net/dgads_cms?retryWrites=true&w=majority
```

Part 2: Cloudinary Setup (Free Media Storage & CDN)

Cloudinary stores and automatically optimizes all client uploaded images (case study covers, testimonials photos, client brand logos) in WebP format.

- **Step 1: Create Account** — Register for a free account at cloudinary.com/signup.
- **Step 2: Get Cloud Name** — Look at your main Dashboard header and copy your **Cloud Name** (e.g., `dgads-agency`). This is your `VITE_CLOUDINARY_CLOUD_NAME`.
- **Step 3: Create Unsigned Preset** — Click the **Settings Icon** at bottom left ➔ **Upload tab** ➔ Scroll down to **Upload presets** ➔ Click **Add upload preset**.
- **Step 4: Set Unsigned Mode** — Change **Signing Mode** to **Unsigned**. Name your preset (e.g., `dgads_preset`) and click **Save**. This is your `VITE_CLOUDINARY_UPLOAD_PRESET`.

Part 3: Complete Environment Variables Reference

Variable Name	Sample Value / Description
MONGODB_URI	mongodb+srv://user:pass@cluster0...mongodb.net/dgads_cms
JWT_SECRET	dgads_secret_jwt_key_2026_x89q3 (Random secret key)
ADMIN_USERNAME	admin (Login username for CMS)
ADMIN_PASSWORD	YourAdminPassword123 (Login password for CMS)
VITE_CLOUDINARY_CLOUD_NAME	dgads-agency (From Cloudinary Dashboard)
VITE_CLOUDINARY_UPLOAD_PRESET	dgads_preset (Unsigned upload preset name)

Part 4: Connecting Variables to Vercel (Production)

To ensure your live website updates automatically whenever your client changes content in the CMS:

1. Go to your **Vercel Dashboard** (vercel.com) and select your agency-website project.
 1. Navigate to **Settings ➡ Environment Variables**.
 1. Add all 6 variables listed in the reference table above.
 1. Click **Save** and trigger a **Redeploy** on Vercel.
 1. **Result:** Client updates in <http://localhost:5174> or live admin panel reflect on the website instantly!